DATU ABUL KHAYR DANGCAL ALONTO:

FROM MNLF COMMANDER TO ARCHITECT OF MINDANAO DEVELOPMENT

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INTRODUCTION

The modern political history of Mindanao cannot be told without confronting a difficult transformation: how a generation of Moro revolutionaries moved from armed struggle to institutional governance. Some resisted that transition. Some were overtaken by it. A few managed to navigate both worlds—carrying the legitimacy of rebellion into the machinery of the state.

Datu Abul Khayr Dangcal Alonto (1945–2019) belonged to that smaller, more complex category.

He was not merely a participant in the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF); he was part of its early command structure, one of the original "Top 90" trainees who formed the backbone of the movement's armed wing. He rose to become Vice Chairman of the organization during a formative and volatile period. Yet his life did not remain confined to insurgency. Over the decades, he would become an elected local executive in Marawi City, a figure in autonomy institutions, a diplomat representing the Republic of the Philippines abroad, a factional leader navigating internal Moro political fractures, and eventually Chairperson of the Mindanao Development Authority (MinDA) at Cabinet rank.

Few careers in Bangsamoro history illustrate so vividly the passage from rebellion to governance.

Alonto's trajectory is not a simple story of conversion—from fighter to peacemaker. It is more layered than that. It reflects the internal evolution of the Moro struggle itself: the realization that armed confrontation, while historically catalytic, could not by itself secure lasting political and economic transformation. Institutions, budgets, infrastructure, and development planning would eventually become as decisive as battlefield strategy.

This article reconstructs that arc. Drawing from contemporary reporting, institutional records, peace-process analyses, and Bangsamoro transitional documents, it traces Alonto's life across five distinct but interconnected phases: early formation in Marawi; revolutionary mobilization and armed leadership; political realignment and autonomy engagement; diplomatic and national roles; and finally, development-centered governance through MinDA. It situates his choices within broader historical contexts—martial law, the Tripoli Agreement, MNLF fragmentation, and the long road to the Bangsamoro political settlement.

To understand Alonto is to understand a generation forced to negotiate between memory and pragmatism, between dignity and compromise, between war and institution-building.

I. FAMILY BACKGROUND AND EARLY LIFE IN MARAWI

Abul Khayr Dangcal Alonto was born in 1945 in Marawi City, at a moment of national transition. The Second World War had just ended. The Philippines was rebuilding. In Mindanao, however, older tensions were quietly intensifying. Demographic shifts, land resettlement policies, and state integration projects were reshaping the balance between indigenous Muslim communities and incoming settlers.

Marawi was not merely a geographic birthplace. It was the intellectual and political center of the Maranao people. Historically known as Dansalan before its renaming, it had long served as a bastion of Islamic scholarship, aristocratic lineage networks, and resistance to colonial penetration. Spanish forces had struggled to subdue it. American administrators eventually established presence, but never fully dissolved its internal power structures. Even into the mid-twentieth century, Marawi retained a strong sense of distinct identity within the Philippine republic.

Alonto was born into one of its prominent families.

His father, Abdul Ghaffur Madki Alangadi Alonto, had served as provincial governor and later as a Philippine ambassador. His mother, Bai Hajja Rasmia Indol Dangcal, came from another respected Maranao lineage. Politics, therefore, was not a distant subject discussed in newspapers; it was embedded in daily life. Governance, negotiation, and representation were familiar conversations within the household.

This upbringing gave Alonto two forms of capital. First, social capital: access to networks across clan structures and political institutions. Second, political literacy: an early understanding of how power operates within both local and national arenas.

Yet growing up in a politically connected family during the 1950s and 1960s also meant witnessing contradictions. While certain Maranao elites maintained influence, broader Moro

communities were increasingly experiencing marginalization. State-sponsored migration from Luzon and the Visayas altered land ownership patterns in Mindanao. Tensions over ancestral domains intensified. Armed settler groups emerged in some areas. Economic development programs often bypassed Muslim-majority provinces.

These developments formed the backdrop of Alonto's formative years.

He pursued higher education beyond Mindanao, studying political science at Cairo University. Cairo during the 1960s was a center of post-colonial discourse. Arab nationalism, Islamic political thought, and Third World solidarity movements were intellectually vibrant. For a young Moro student, exposure to these currents offered language and theoretical framing for grievances already felt at home. Concepts such as self-determination, anti-imperialism, and national liberation were not abstract—they resonated directly with the Bangsamoro condition.

Upon returning to the Philippines, Alonto also undertook legal studies at San Beda College. This legal training would later prove significant. It sharpened his appreciation for institutional frameworks and constitutional mechanisms—knowledge that would become increasingly relevant as the Moro struggle moved from purely armed confrontation toward negotiations and autonomy design.

However, it was not academic exposure alone that propelled him toward activism.

The late 1960s witnessed the eruption of the Jabidah controversy, involving the reported killing of Muslim military trainees. Whether examined through investigative journalism or oral accounts, the incident had a profound psychological impact on Muslim communities. For many young Moro intellectuals, it symbolized systemic disregard for Muslim lives and deepened distrust of central authorities.

Alonto belonged to this generation.

In response to the growing sense of injustice, he became involved in organizing Muslim youth. One of the formations associated with this period was LAM ALIF, a youth organization composed of politically conscious Muslim students and activists. Several of its members would later emerge as key figures within the Moro National Liberation Front.

The trajectory from youth organizing to armed movement was not instantaneous, but it was increasingly foreseeable. By the end of the 1960s, peaceful appeals were widely perceived as insufficient. Structural grievances—land dispossession, political underrepresentation, communal violence—were intensifying rather than easing.

For Alonto and his contemporaries, the question was no longer whether change was needed, but how it would be pursued.

The answer, in time, would take him far from the lecture halls of Cairo and Manila—into the ranks of a revolutionary organization that would reshape Mindanao's political history.

II. POLITICAL AWAKENING AND ENTRY INTO THE MORO NATIONAL LIBERATION FRONT

By the close of the 1960s, political consciousness among Moro youth had moved beyond scattered protest and campus-based discussion. What had begun as localized expressions of grievance was slowly coalescing into a broader nationalist imagination. For young activists like Abul Khayr Dangcal Alonto, the question was no longer whether the Bangsamoro people were oppressed; the question was what form organized resistance should take.

Several forces converged to shape this moment.

First, the memory of Jabidah continued to circulate, reinforced by new stories of military abuses, land grabbing, and communal violence. These narratives were not isolated rumors but lived realities for families in Cotabato, Lanao, Sulu, and Zamboanga. Second, a growing number of Moro students were returning from abroad—particularly from the Middle East—bringing with them exposure to anti-colonial movements and liberation struggles in Asia and Africa. Third, informal networks of Muslim intellectuals, ulama, and community leaders were quietly debating the possibility of a unified Moro political organization.

Alonto stood at the intersection of these currents.

His earlier involvement in Muslim youth organizing placed him in contact with individuals who were already moving toward clandestine coordination. These were not yet soldiers; they were

organizers, couriers, and political educators. Meetings were small, discreet, and often framed as study sessions or community consultations. But beneath the surface, a strategic shift was underway.

The idea gaining traction was radical for its time: that Moros constituted a nation, and that this nation had the right to self-determination.

This framing departed from earlier Muslim political approaches that sought accommodation within the Philippine state through elite bargaining. Instead, it articulated a collective identity rooted in shared history, religion, territory, and experience of marginalization.

When the Moro National Liberation Front formally emerged as an organized movement in the early 1970s, Alonto was already part of its inner circle. His combination of education, political maturity, and family connections made him a natural recruit for leadership responsibilities.

Unlike mass-based recruitment later in the conflict, early MNLF recruitment was highly selective. Prospective members were screened not only for commitment, but for discipline and discretion. The movement understood that premature exposure could lead to swift suppression.

Alonto's entry into the MNLF was therefore not a spontaneous act. It was the culmination of years of political evolution.

He was not joining an existing army.

He was helping to build one.

At this stage, the MNLF was still more political organization than military force. Its early emphasis lay in ideological consolidation, organizational design, and external linkages—particularly with Muslim countries sympathetic to anti-colonial struggles.

Alonto's role during this period leaned toward political-military integration. He participated in discussions about strategy, organizational hierarchy, and recruitment patterns. Even before formal combat operations began, he was being prepared for command responsibility.

This preparation would soon become explicit.

III. THE “TOP 90” AND THE FORMATION OF A REVOLUTIONARY CADRE

In 1969, a pivotal decision was made by emerging MNLF leadership: a select group of recruits would be sent abroad for intensive guerrilla warfare training. This group would later be remembered as the “Top 90.”

Abul Khayr Dangcal Alonto was among them.

The existence of the Top 90 reflects a crucial strategic insight. The MNLF did not intend to rely solely on spontaneous uprising. It sought to create a disciplined core of cadres who could serve as trainers, organizers, and commanders once armed struggle expanded.

Training reportedly took place in Pulau Pangkor, Malaysia, and lasted roughly a year. Details about the curriculum remain limited in public sources, partly because secrecy was an essential component of survival. What can be reasonably inferred from later accounts is that the training combined:

- Basic guerrilla tactics
- Weapons handling
- Small-unit organization
- Political education
- Revolutionary discipline

The emphasis was not merely on fighting, but on building a movement.

For Alonto, this experience represented a decisive turning point.

He was no longer only an activist or student of politics. He was being transformed into a revolutionary officer.

Equally important was the composition of the Top 90 itself. The cohort included Moros from different ethnolinguistic groups—Maranao, Maguindanao, Tausug, Sama, and others. This diversity reflected the MNLF’s aspiration to transcend local identities and forge a unified Bangsamoro struggle.

Living, training, and struggling together in a foreign environment fostered a sense of shared destiny among the trainees. These bonds would later shape leadership relationships, alliances, and rivalries within the movement.

Upon completion of training, Alonto and his fellow Top 90 members returned to Mindanao not as anonymous recruits, but as foundational pillars of the emerging armed wing.

Alonto was assigned to the Lanao area, where he would assume field command responsibilities.

His ascent within the organization was rapid.

He became recognized not only as a capable commander, but as a political figure within the movement. Eventually, he would be elevated to Vice Chairman of the MNLF, placing him directly beneath Nur Misuari in the early leadership hierarchy.

This dual status—military commander and senior political officer—was significant. It meant that Alonto participated in both battlefield planning and strategic policy discussions.

The war, from his vantage point, was inseparable from politics.

IV. ROLE IN THE EARLY ARMED STRUGGLE

When open hostilities erupted in the early 1970s, the MNLF faced an enormous challenge. It confronted a centralized state with superior firepower, air assets, and formal military infrastructure. What the movement possessed instead was popular support in certain areas, familiarity with terrain, and the commitment of its cadres.

As commander of MNLF forces in Lanao, Alonto operated in one of the conflict's most sensitive theaters.

Lanao was densely populated, politically complex, and deeply embedded in clan networks. Military action in such an environment could not be separated from social consequences. A single clash could ripple outward into clan feuds, displacement, and cycles of retaliation.

Alonto's responsibilities therefore extended beyond tactical engagements. He had to manage relationships with community elders, religious leaders, and local commanders. He had to ensure

discipline among fighters. He had to navigate the fine line between revolutionary necessity and civilian protection.

Contemporary peace-process analyses describe him as one of the principal early field commanders tasked with territorial responsibilities. This placed him among a small group of leaders who bore the burden of translating national-level directives into local operational reality.

Accounts from later years suggest that Alonto's leadership style during this period emphasized organization and coordination rather than indiscriminate violence. While war inevitably involved bloodshed, the strategic goal remained political: to pressure the Philippine state into recognizing the Bangsamoro cause.

By the mid-1970s, however, it had become clear that armed struggle alone would not produce decisive victory. The state was not collapsing. International support was uneven. Civilians were bearing heavy costs.

It was in this context that new pathways began to emerge.

V. VICE MAYORSHIP, ACTING MAYORSHIP, AND TURN TO THE UNDERGROUND

One of the most revealing episodes in Abul Khayr Dangcal Alonto's political life is the period when he simultaneously inhabited two worlds: formal local governance and underground revolutionary struggle.

In 1972, Alonto ran for Vice Mayor of Marawi City and won by an overwhelming margin. He was widely regarded as one of the youngest city executives in the country at that time. The victory was not accidental. It reflected both his family's political standing and his growing personal reputation as a principled, articulate, and capable leader.

At first glance, participation in electoral politics might appear inconsistent with membership in an armed revolutionary organization. But within the political logic of the period, the two were not mutually exclusive.

Many Moro leaders of Alonto's generation viewed electoral office as another arena of struggle. Holding local government positions allowed them to:

- Protect communities from abuses where possible
- Channel resources toward neglected areas
- Build political legitimacy among constituents
- Test whether meaningful reform within the system was still feasible

For Alonto, the vice mayoralty was not an abandonment of the MNLF cause. It was a tactical extension of it.

In 1974, he briefly served as Acting Mayor of Marawi City. His assumption of this role placed him in direct confrontation with the realities of governance under Martial Law. The Marcos regime had centralized power, curtailed civil liberties, and empowered security forces with sweeping authority. Reports of arbitrary arrests, disappearances, and torture were widespread, particularly in Muslim areas.

The space for reformist local governance quickly shrank.

Before he could be formally sworn in as full mayor, Alonto made a decisive choice. He left his position and went underground to rejoin his MNLF comrades.

This move signaled a conclusion reached through experience: electoral participation under Martial Law could not deliver the structural change that Moros sought. The political arena had become too tightly controlled by the central regime.

Alonto's return to clandestine activity also underscored a personal principle that would characterize his career—he was willing to relinquish formal power when he believed it had become morally or strategically meaningless.

The episode also cemented his reputation among MNLF ranks as a leader who did not use public office as a shield from risk. He had already held power and given it up.

That mattered.

VI. INTERNAL MNLF FRACTURES AND STRATEGIC REALIGNMENTS

By the late 1970s, the Moro National Liberation Front was no longer the unified organization it had been during its early years.

Several fault lines had emerged:

- Disagreements over leadership style
- Divergent views on negotiations with the Marcos government
- Tensions between centralized authority and regional commanders
- Personal rivalries shaped by war-time experiences

These internal strains were intensified by external developments.

In 1976, the Tripoli Agreement was signed between the Philippine government and the MNLF, brokered by the Organization of Islamic Conference. The agreement recognized the principle of autonomy for Muslim Mindanao, marking the first major political concession to Moro demands.

However, implementation proved deeply contentious.

Many within the MNLF viewed the Marcos government's version of autonomy as diluted and insincere. Others believed that imperfect autonomy was preferable to endless war.

Within this context, Abul Khayr Alonto found himself navigating a complicated terrain.

In 1978, he was removed from the MNLF central committee by Nur Misuari. Shortly thereafter, Alonto entered into a separate accommodation with the Marcos government.

This episode has often been simplified as defection or betrayal.

A more careful reading suggests something more complex.

Alonto did not abandon the goal of Moro self-governance. Instead, he shifted his arena of struggle from insurgency toward the emerging autonomy framework.

He became involved in the institutions created in the wake of the Tripoli Agreement. He served as an assemblyman in the regional autonomous structure, later became interim head of a regional autonomous government, and eventually served as Speaker of a regional legislative assembly.

These were fragile, contested institutions. They lacked stable resources and clear constitutional footing. They were often overshadowed by continuing armed conflict.

Yet for leaders like Alonto, they represented a new battlefield.

Instead of commanding fighters, he now had to command budgets, legislative procedures, and bureaucratic processes.

This transition required a different kind of discipline.

Former revolutionaries entering governance confronted immediate challenges:

- Limited administrative experience
- Patronage-driven politics
- Weak institutional culture
- Persistent suspicion from both government and rebel ranks

Alonto's willingness to remain inside these imperfect structures suggests a strategic calculation. He appeared to believe that autonomy, however flawed, provided a platform from which future gains could be pursued.

In this sense, his realignment did not mark an abandonment of the Moro struggle, but an evolution in its form.

From this point onward, Alonto increasingly defined his role as an institution-builder rather than an insurgent commander.

VII. FROM REVOLUTIONARY TO AUTONOMY INSTITUTION-BUILDER

By the early 1980s, Abul Khayr Dangcal Alonto had crossed a threshold that many former revolutionaries struggle to navigate: he committed himself to the slow, frustrating, and often thankless work of institution-building.

This shift did not occur overnight.

It emerged from cumulative experience—years of war, internal movement fractures, failed ceasefires, and partial political settlements. Alonto had seen firsthand both the power and the limits of armed struggle. He had also experienced the limits of symbolic political agreements that were not matched by serious implementation.

Autonomy, imperfect as it was, offered a new terrain.

For Alonto, autonomy institutions were not end-goals. They were scaffolding—structures upon which more meaningful self-governance might eventually be constructed.

As an assemblyman in the regional autonomous government and later as interim head and Speaker of a regional legislative body, Alonto immersed himself in legislative work, policy formulation, and administrative management. These roles demanded a very different skill set from guerrilla command.

Instead of issuing battlefield orders, he now had to:

- Negotiate with political rivals
- Build coalitions inside legislative chambers
- Interpret legal frameworks
- Work within budget constraints

- Engage national agencies

This transition was not glamorous.

Early autonomy institutions were plagued by:

- Weak funding
- Ambiguous legal authority
- Overlapping jurisdictions
- Persistent interference from the central government

Many former revolutionaries grew disillusioned and returned to armed struggle or withdrew from politics altogether.

Alonto did not.

He stayed.

His persistence suggests a long-term strategic orientation. He appeared to recognize that sustainable political gains would only emerge through cumulative institutional practice, however slow and imperfect.

This period also sharpened his understanding of governance realities. He witnessed how patronage networks distorted policymaking. He observed how bureaucratic inertia could derail even well-intentioned programs. He saw how the absence of professional civil service systems undermined continuity.

These experiences would later inform his emphasis on development planning, inter-agency coordination, and infrastructure-driven integration when he headed MinDA.

In a sense, the autonomy years were Alonto's apprenticeship in civilian statecraft.

VIII. DIPLOMATIC CAREER AND INTERNATIONAL ENGAGEMENT

In 1994, Abul Khayr Alonto was appointed Ambassador Extraordinary and Plenipotentiary of the Republic of the Philippines to Nigeria and several other African states.

For a former MNLF commander, this appointment carried deep symbolic weight.

It represented the Philippine state's formal recognition that former adversaries could be legitimate representatives of national interests. It also reflected confidence in Alonto's capacity to operate within the norms of international diplomacy.

His diplomatic posting expanded his worldview further.

Diplomacy exposed him to:

- Multilateral negotiations
- Development cooperation frameworks
- Investment promotion strategies
- Regional integration initiatives

These experiences reinforced a lesson he had already begun to internalize: political solutions require economic foundations.

During this period, Alonto increasingly articulated Moro concerns not only in terms of historical injustice, but also in terms of development deficits—poverty, infrastructure gaps, unemployment, and lack of market access.

This framing did not replace identity-based claims. Instead, it complemented them.

The Bangsamoro struggle, in Alonto's evolving view, was as much about building viable economies as it was about asserting political rights.

His diplomatic service thus functioned as another stage in his transformation—from revolutionary commander, to autonomy politician, to development-oriented statesman.

IX. RE-EMERGENCE IN MNLF LEADERSHIP AND PEACE ADVOCACY

Although Alonto had long been operating within government institutions, he never severed ties with the broader Moro revolutionary community.

In 2014, amid leadership disputes within the MNLF following Nur Misuari's political and military setbacks, Alonto emerged as one of the figures asserting a claim to MNLF chairmanship.

More important than the title itself was his public position.

Alonto openly supported the peace process between the Philippine government and the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF), including the proposed Bangsamoro Basic Law. He framed peace not as surrender, but as strategic transition.

He argued that:

- Armed struggle had fulfilled its historical role
- The political battlefield had shifted
- The future of the Bangsamoro lay in negotiated political settlements and democratic ratification

Crucially, he emphasized peaceful, non-violent, Islamic, and democratic means of resolving political disputes.

This stance placed him firmly within the camp of revolutionary elders who accepted that the next phase of struggle would be fought through legislation, plebiscites, and institution-building rather than through armed confrontation.

It also reflected continuity rather than rupture.

From his early years, Alonto had always treated war as instrumental rather than romantic. His later peace advocacy can therefore be understood as consistent with his long-held view that political objectives, not perpetual conflict, were paramount.

X. CHAIRMANSHIP OF THE MINDANAO DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY AND DEVELOPMENT VISION

In 2016, President Rodrigo Duterte appointed Abul Khayr Dangcal Alonto as Chairperson of the Mindanao Development Authority (MinDA), a Cabinet-rank position.

For Alonto, MinDA represented the culmination of decades of political evolution.

MinDA's mandate is to accelerate Mindanao's socioeconomic development by:

- Promoting investments
- Strengthening infrastructure
- Enhancing inter-regional connectivity
- Supporting peace and development initiatives

Alonto embraced a core proposition:

Peace will not survive without development.
Development will not succeed without peace.

Under his leadership, MinDA promoted the concept of Mindanao Development Corridors—geographic growth zones designed to disperse economic activity beyond traditional urban centers. The objective was to ensure that development benefits reached historically marginalized areas, including conflict-affected provinces.

He also pushed for:

- Expansion of ecozones
- Strengthening of inter-island shipping routes
- Advocacy for a Mindanao railway system
- Active participation in the Brunei–Indonesia–Malaysia–Philippines East ASEAN Growth Area (BIMP-EAGA)

These initiatives were not abstract planning exercises. They were conceived as mechanisms to physically and economically integrate Mindanao, reducing the isolation that had long fueled underdevelopment and grievance.

Alonto frequently framed infrastructure as a unifying force. Roads, ports, and railways were not merely economic assets; they were instruments of social cohesion.

In this sense, MinDA became Alonto's final battlefield.

Not one of gunfire.

But one of blueprints, budgets, and inter-agency negotiations.

XI. LEADERSHIP STYLE AND IDEAS

Those who worked with Alonto often described him as soft-spoken, patient, and strategic.

He preferred persuasion to confrontation.

He was comfortable operating behind the scenes.

These traits were shaped by a lifetime of navigating volatile political environments.

He understood that public grandstanding could derail delicate negotiations. He valued incremental progress over dramatic gestures.

Ideologically, Alonto blended:

- Moro nationalism
- Islamic ethical framing
- Pragmatic governance

He did not abandon identity-based politics. But he increasingly situated identity within a broader development and governance agenda.

For him, dignity was inseparable from livelihood.

XII. HISTORICAL SIGNIFICANCE AND LEGACY

Abul Khayr Dangcal Alonto's historical significance lies not in a single dramatic moment, but in the arc of his life.

He embodied the transformation of the Moro struggle from armed rebellion to institutional politics.

He demonstrated that former revolutionaries could become effective administrators.

He showed that loyalty to a cause does not require permanent allegiance to a single tactic.

His life illustrates a difficult truth:

Liberation movements must eventually learn how to govern—or risk becoming trapped in endless resistance.

Alonto chose the harder path.

CONCLUSION

Datu Abul Khayr Dangcal Alonto was not a perfect man.

He made controversial choices.

He navigated political compromises.

He shifted alliances.

Yet across five decades of public life, one constant remained: his commitment to the welfare and dignity of the Bangsamoro people.

From guerrilla training camps to city hall, from autonomy assemblies to diplomatic posts, from revolutionary meetings to Cabinet deliberations, he carried with him the memory of a wounded people and the hope that their future could be better.

His story is not only about one man.

It is about a generation that learned—through pain, failure, and perseverance—that building peace is as demanding as waging war.

And sometimes, even more courageous.